

colour screen, more memory, a microSD slot, 320 x 240 pixel screens offering 65K colour depth and a camera. It also came with a trackwheel for navigation which was later replaced with a mini trackball in the BlackBerry Pearl.

The 8100 was the first of the Pearl series and came with a media player for music and ringtone settings. The 8000 series was known for the Pearl and the Curve series. The BlackBerry Curve was an instant crowd favourite thanks to the affordable price and the increasing popularity of smartphones. The BlackBerry Curve had an optical trackpad as opposed to the long standing trackball navigation seen in the earlier models. In 2008, the first BlackBerry flip phones were introduced and resembled clamshells and had an internal display of 240 x 320 and an external display of 128 x 160 pixels.

BlackBerry kept getting better and better with every series they came with. The BlackBerry Bold from the 9000 series was one such device when introduced and did not disappoint. With the iconic leather cover and chic look it was the first all touch device and came with a 480 x 320 pixel display, along with a 2-megapixel camera, Bluetooth, Wi-Fi 802.11a/g/b and microSD expansion up to 16GB. And later with BlackBerry Storm they removed the physical Qwerty keypad and featured a full touch screen keypad which also marked their entry into full touch but they couldn't match the competition from the iPhone. The increasing complaints about the incompetency of the touchscreen and lack of apps in comparison to the other smartphones available at the time led to launch of various modules of the 9000 series, but it could never catch up. Even with the BlackBerry Torch 9800 model with a touch display which could slide up to reveal a full QWERTY keyboard the touch experience else-



where was far better. During the summer of 2011, the thinnest BlackBerry phone at the time, BlackBerry Bold Touch was introduced with an optical trackpad, a full QWERTY keyboard and a touchscreen interface. It offered a 5-megapixel camera and NFC on board.

BLACKBERRY 10 OS

BlackBerry's own operating system BB10 was first featured in their 2013 model BlackBerry Z10 and had a 4.2-inch display offering a 1280 x 768 pixel resolution. An 8-megapixel rear camera was on board, as well as a 2-megapixel front camera and it offered a battery life of 10 hours talk time. It was a big launch for BlackBerry in itself with their own OS and a full touchscreen.

Here at Digit, we were impressed with the new OS, and when we conducted an objective, out-of-the box test of OSes, we actually found that BB10 OS was by far the best built OS of the lot. However, this was also the time when Apple and Google could do no wrong, and Android and iOS were ruling the roost with third party apps. Think of it, none of us even thinks about the native capabilities of our phones, we look for apps to do everything important with them.

The same year the BlackBerry Q5 and BlackBerry Z30 were also launched to try and combat Android, but they never stood a chance.

BlackBerry then returned to their roots targeting their business users. The 2014 BlackBerry Passport, a device featuring a 4.5 inch square screen with a 1440 x 1440 pixel resolution and a QWERTY keyboard. Then came the BlackBerry Classic which allowed users to install Android apps. Following their partner-

ship with Foxconn, four months after Classic, came BlackBerry Leap, with no physical QWERTY keyboard due to agreement resulting in a cheaper touch device. Leap was the last device with BB10 OS.

NEW BEGINNINGS

BlackBerry Priv was the first Android device built by BlackBerry. It had the full QWERTY keyboard, but hidden under the slide up display, along with an 18-megapixel camera, Quad HD display and the Qualcomm Snapdragon 808 processor. The handset was a little large due to the sliding keyboard but nevertheless a classic BlackBerry phone with better features. What killed it was the price. BlackBerry sold its licenses to TCL who launched the BlackBerry KeyOne, which was nothing like a regular BlackBerry device. It featured a keyboard directly beneath the display, and had soft-touch grip rear and a very unique 4.35 inch screen with a resolution of 1620x1080. Its impressive 3,500mAh battery and Snapdragon 625 processor could go almost upto 2 days without charging and ran smoothly with little to no delay. The BlackBerry Key2 was made to look more premium, lighter and durable and also had a dual 12-megapixel camera on the back. It was edgy and not easy to hold as KeyOne.

BlackBerry 5G, a smartphone with a physical keyboard which was to be released in 2021, is not here yet, and they say it's delayed to 2022. Onward Mobility purchased the brand from TCL.

Die hard fans of BlackBerry may be ever decreasing in numbers, and it may seem that a BlackBerry resurgence is next to impossible, but remember that Apple was written off once as well. BlackBerry might just need its own Steve Jobs-like icon to revive it. Elon Musk maybe? If you're a die-hard BB fan, start tweeting Musk to ask him! 

